Module 5 · Workbook answers

Tafakkur (Reflection)

Video: 32 min **Answer sheet**

This module teaches tafakkur (reflection): stepping back from the small worries of the day to see Allah's love shown in your own body, in the whole of creation, in your talents and in your blessings. Five simple steps give you a new perspective, so your problems shrink back to their true size and you hand them to the One who runs the universe.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1 **Revision, and what tafakkur means**

So far the course has built huḍūr (presence with Allah) in three layers. The foundation, from Surah Ta-Ha 20:46: Allah is with you, Allah sees you, Allah hears you. Then visualisation, from the hadith on ihsan (excellence in worship): worship Allah as if you see Him, for example by picturing a place where you feel close to Him, or simply the name of Allah. Then communication: bringing Allah your sins, blessings, needs and problems and sending them up to Him. Tafakkur with ihsan is to reflect and think on a matter and see in it the manifestation of Allah's loving creation. It is a new addition to the course, and the next module will cover deliberation.

2 **To an ant, a crumb is huge: the power of perspective**

We get boxed into our day-to-day issues: the children are giving us trouble, there is a headache here and a problem there. To an ant, a crumb is huge, and if we stay small, our issues become huge too. Tafakkur means taking a step back and seeing that Allah's love is everywhere and that your life is full of blessings. From a plane, a truck that could easily kill you shrinks, as you climb, to the size of an ant; for the eagle that rises high enough, even mountains become small. If you remember one word from this module, remember perspective. Allah praises those of understanding who remember Him standing, sitting and lying down and reflect on the creation of the heavens and the earth (3:190–191).

3 **Your problem is not bigger than Allah, and you are dear to Him**

In the live session everyone watched a video of creation together. Whatever problem you are facing is not bigger than Allah; we only forget Him when we are lost in the nitty-gritty of our issues. That is tawakkul (trust in Allah). Seeing creation shows us how small we are, yet we are also deeply significant: the Prophet ﷺ told the Companion Zahir, who felt he was of little worth, that with Allah he was precious. If we pay attention to an ant, it is out of mercy; the One who controls everything in that video has not forgotten us, so how could He not answer our du'as (prayers)? Dhikr (remembrance) is remembering that before all of this there was only Allah; creation can distract us, but in reality there is just Allah.

4

Step 1a: the signs within yourself

First come into presence: Allah is with you, sees you, and hears your thoughts, every breath and every blood vessel. Allah promises to show us His signs in the horizons and within ourselves (41:53), so start with yourself. Your heart beats billions of times in a lifetime without rest. When you overheat, your blood vessels widen to release the heat. Your diaphragm keeps you breathing without a thought, filling hundreds of millions of tiny air sacs in your lungs. Each bone suits its job: the skull's plates fuse together, the rib cage expands, the arch of the foot carries your weight. Some muscles work automatically (the heart), some semi-automatically (blinking) and some only on command (the biceps). Your hearing keeps watch while you sleep and wakes you if there is danger, and in 17:36 Allah mentions hearing first. As a saying puts it: within you is folded the whole universe.

5

Step 1b: the signs in creation

Next, look at the design in nature. Spider silk is remarkably strong for its weight. Termites, many of them blind, build mounds that, for their size, would dwarf our tallest buildings. The firefly makes light that gives off almost no heat, far more efficiently than a light bulb. The Crystal Palace was inspired by the giant water lily, and robotic arms by the elephant's trunk. Think of the defences Allah has given creatures: the chameleon changing colour, butterflies with false eyes to scare predators, the beetle that sprays a burning chemical, animals that puff themselves up to look bigger. The earth's magnetic field shields us from harmful particles from the sun. Ant colonies of vast numbers each know their jobs, with no arguments, communicating by scent. Birds fly in a V shape to save energy and take turns at the front, and we still do not fully understand how animals migrate to the exact same spot. How does each creature know what to do?

6

Step 2: your talents are reflections of Allah's names

Now reflect on every talent, strength and ability you have, and see that they come from Allah and are reflections of His sifat (attributes), given to you out of love. This is the answer to low self-esteem and thinking "I'm rubbish". If you are creative, that reflects al-Musawwir (the Fashioner). If you are good with numbers and accounts, al-Muhsi (the One who counts all things). If you can fix things or are good at DIY, al-Jabbar (the One who restores and sets right); the word algebra comes from the Arabic al-jabr, from the same root. Allah is al-Wahhab (the Supreme Bestower), and the Arabic word for a talent, mawhiba, comes from the same root.

7

Step 3: your greatest blessings

Reflect on your greatest blessings, such as your relationships, your work and your wealth, and see that in reality it is Allah showing His love through them. As you reflect on the vast universe and your place in it, ask what Allah has actually given you, and thank and appreciate it deeply. Allah calls spouses, and the affection and mercy between them, signs for people who reflect (30:21). Sometimes it is hard to feel that a spouse or children are a blessing, but they are. If you tried to count your blessings, you could not.

8

Steps 4 and 5: put your problems in boxes and ascend

Step 4: reflect on your trials, problems and needs, picture each one, and place it in its own box: family, children, work, even the car. Step 5: like a plane taking off, picture yourself slowly ascending and leaving those boxes behind. Zoom out to the skies, the earth, the solar system and the galaxies, as far as you can. In that state, rely on the One who controls the heavens and the earth to deal with your affairs, and ask Him to resolve them. He manages the whole universe, from the ant colony to the earth turning around the sun to your own heartbeat, so your problem should not overwhelm you. Then take that state into your salah. To practise again, watch a gentle video of creation and "swim in Allah's creation": we share this world with it, and with our families, for a reason, so engage with it. Use whichever technique from the course you need: reflection, visualisation or communication.

From the Qur'an and the Sunnah

إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ وَٱخْتِلَٰفِ ٱلَّيْلِ وَٱلنَّهَارِ لَءَايَٰتٍ لِّأُو۟لِى ٱلْأَلْبَٰبِ ۝ ٱلَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ ٱللَّهَ قِيَٰمًا وَقُعُودًا وَعَلَىٰ جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَٰذَا بَٰطِلًا سُبْحَٰنَكَ فَقِنَا عَذَابَ ٱلنَّارِ

Indeed, in the creation of the heavens and the earth and the alternation of the night and the day are signs for those of understanding – who remember Allāh while standing or sitting or [lying] on their sides and give thought to the creation of the heavens and the earth, [saying], "Our Lord, You did not create this aimlessly; exalted are You [above such a thing]; then protect us from the punishment of the Fire."

Surah Al 'Imran 3:190–191

سَنُرِيهِمْ ءَايَٰتِنَا فِي ٱلْءَافَاقِ وَفِىٓ أَنفُسِهِمْ حَتَّىٰ يَتَبَيَّنَ لَهُمْ أَنَّهُ ٱلْحَقُّ ۗ أَوَلَمْ يَكْفِ بِرَبِّكَ أَنَّهُۥ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَىْءٍ شَهِيدٌ

We will show them Our signs in the horizons and within themselves until it becomes clear to them that it is the truth. But is it not sufficient concerning your Lord that He is, over all things, a Witness?

Surah Fussilat 41:53

وَلَا تَقْفُ مَا لَيْسَ لَكَ بِهِۦ عِلْمٌ ۚ إِنَّ ٱلسَّمْعَ وَٱلْبَصَرَ وَٱلْفُؤَادَ كُلُّ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ كَانَ عَنْهُ مَسْـُٔولًا

And do not pursue that of which you have no knowledge. Indeed, the hearing, the sight and the heart – about all those [one] will be questioned.

Surah al-Isra 17:36

وَمِنْ ءَايَٰتِهِۦٓ أَنْ خَلَقَ لَكُم مِّنْ أَنفُسِكُمْ أَزْوَٰجًا لِّتَسْكُنُوٓا۟ إِلَيْهَا وَجَعَلَ بَيْنَكُم مَّوَدَّةً وَرَحْمَةً ۚ إِنَّ فِى ذَٰلِكَ لَءَايَٰتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ

And of His signs is that He created for you from yourselves mates that you may find tranquility in them; and He placed between you affection and mercy. Indeed in that are signs for a people who give thought.

Surah ar-Rum 30:21

> *It is reported that the Prophet ﷺ came up to the Companion Zahir in the market and, in fond jest, called out, "Who will buy this servant?" Zahir said, "O Messenger of Allah, then you will find me of little worth." The Prophet ﷺ replied, "But with Allah you are not of little worth; with Allah you are precious."*

Practical exercises

The five-step tafakkur

1. Sit somewhere quiet and come into presence: Allah is with me, Allah sees me, Allah hears me.
2. Step 1: notice your heartbeat, your breathing and your blinking, then picture creation around you: insects, birds, trees, clouds, the sun and the planets, all run by Allah.
3. Step 2: name your talents and see each as a reflection of one of Allah's beautiful names.
4. Step 3: bring to mind your blessings (family, work, wealth) and thank Allah for each one.
5. Steps 4 and 5: put each problem in its own box, then picture yourself ascending like a plane, leaving the boxes in Allah's hands as you zoom out to the galaxies.
6. Go straight to salah in that state, then write how it felt.

My talents and my blessings

1. List three talents or strengths you have, however small.
2. Next to each, write the name of Allah it reflects (for example al-Musawwir, al-Muhsi, al-Jabbar, al-Wahhab).
3. List your greatest blessings in relationships, work and wealth.
4. Include one relationship that feels hard right now, and write one way it is still a blessing.
5. Thank Allah for each one in your own words.

Swim in Allah's creation

1. Spend ten minutes outside looking at the sky, or watching a gentle video of creation.
2. Choose one creature, plant or part of your body and ask: how does it know what to do?
3. Notice Allah's love and care in it, and how small your current worry looks beside it.
4. Write down the sign you saw and what it taught you about Allah.

7-day practice: tafakkur

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Did the five-step tafakkur							
Reflected on one sign in myself or in creation							
Thanked Allah for a talent or blessing							
Left a problem with Allah, then prayed							

Reflection questions and answers

1. What "crumb" in your life has felt huge recently? How does it look when you step back and see it from higher up?

> To an ant, a crumb is huge, and if we stay small, our issues become huge too. Tafakkur (reflection) means stepping back for perspective: from a climbing plane, a truck shrinks to the size of an ant, and for the eagle even mountains look small. For example: "An argument with my sister had taken over my whole week. Seen from higher up, beside everything Allah runs, it became something I could leave with Him and handle calmly."

2. Which sign in your own body amazed you most, and what does it tell you about Allah's care for you?

> Allah promises to show us His signs within ourselves (41:53). The session points to a heart that beats billions of times without rest, blood vessels that widen to release heat, a diaphragm that keeps you breathing without a thought, bones each suited to their job, and hearing that keeps watch while you sleep. For example: "My hearing amazed me most. It stays on guard while I sleep, which shows me Allah is caring for me even when I am completely unaware."

3. Which example from creation stayed with you, and why?

> The session gave many signs in creation: spider silk, termite mounds, the firefly's cool light, the water lily behind the Crystal Palace, the chameleon, butterflies with false eyes, the earth's magnetic field, ant colonies working without arguments, and birds flying in a V. The key question is: how does each creature know what to do? For example: "The birds taking turns at the front of the V stayed with me. Allah teaches each one its job, so He will not leave me without guidance either."

4. Which of your talents could you now see as a reflection of one of Allah's names? How might that change the way you see yourself?

> Every talent and strength you have comes from Allah, as a reflection of His sifat (attributes) given out of love, and this is the answer to thinking "I'm rubbish". Creativity reflects al-Musawwir, a gift for numbers al-Muhsi, and fixing things al-Jabbar; a talent (mawhiba) shares its root with al-Wahhab, the Supreme Bestower. For example: "I'm good at DIY, which reflects al-Jabbar. Instead of saying I have no real skills, I can see it as a gift and use it with gratitude."

5. Which blessing, perhaps a person, have you been taking for granted or finding hard to see as a blessing?

> Step 3 asks us to see our relationships, work and wealth as Allah showing His love. Allah calls spouses, and the affection and mercy between them, signs for people who reflect (30:21). Sometimes it is hard to feel that a spouse or children are a blessing, but they are, and if we tried to count our blessings we could not. For example: "My teenage daughter has been hard work lately, but she is a gift from Allah, and I want to thank Him for her rather than only notice the arguments."

6. When you put your problems in boxes and ascended, what did you feel? Which problem was hardest to leave behind?

> In Step 4 each trial goes into its own box (family, children, work, even the car), and in Step 5 you rise like a plane, zooming out to the skies, the solar system and the galaxies, relying on the One who controls the heavens and the earth. He runs everything from the ant colony to your heartbeat, so no problem should overwhelm you. For example: "I felt lighter as the boxes shrank. The work box was hardest to leave, because I feel I must fix everything myself."

7. How did the story of Zahir change how you feel about being small, yet precious to Allah?

> Zahir felt he was of little worth, yet the Prophet ﷺ told him that with Allah he was precious. Seeing creation shows how small we are, but also how significant: if we notice an ant out of mercy, the One who controls everything has not forgotten us, so how could He not answer our du'as (prayers)? For example: "I used to feel that my small life could not matter to Allah. Now I feel small beside His creation, yet precious and cared for."

My action plan

- [ ] I will do the five-step tafakkur once a day this week, ideally just before a salah.
- [ ] I will pause on one sign in my body or in creation each day and say subhanAllah.
- [ ] I will see my talents as gifts from al-Wahhab and use them beautifully, not put myself down.
- [ ] I will thank Allah for one blessing each day, including the people closest to me.
- [ ] When a problem feels huge, I will step back, put it in a box and leave it with Allah.